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# Toxic leadership in high-performance sports and its consequences for mental health and performance: a scoping review

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**ABSTRACT**

This scoping review aimed to identify the current state of knowledge on toxic leadership in high-performance sports and its consequences for mental health and performance at individual, interpersonal, and organizational levels. Abstract screening ($n = 768$) and full-text review ($n = 83$) resulted in the inclusion of 26 studies, predominantly conducted in North America and Europe. Studies used inconsistent definitions, theoretical frameworks, and methodological approaches to study darker or toxic leadership. Several antecedents and maintaining factors to toxic leadership were identified, such as individual leader characteristics, a performance-oriented culture, status/power structures, and a lack of reporting processes or consequences within organizations. The empirical literature provided initial support for the negative consequences of toxic leadership on athletes' mental health, injuries, and motivation to remain in high-performance sports. Few studies have investigated the consequences of toxic leadership on sports organizations, staff or coaches. We conclude that research on toxic leadership in high-performance sports is in its early stages, with an underdeveloped understanding of how problematic leadership can be detected, prevented, and addressed to minimize its impact in sports. Researchers, governing bodies, and sports organizations must intensify their efforts to comprehend the emergence and persistence of toxic leadership within high-performance sports environments.

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**KEYWORDS**
Abuse; Dark triad; Elite sport; Destructive leadership; Toxic culture

Media disclosures, anecdotal reports, and safeguarding reviews increasingly suggest that problematic or abusive leadership can be present in sports environments worldwide (e.g. Canadian Centre for Ethics in Sports, 2022; Human Rights Watch, 2020, 2021; Sport

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Integrity Australia, 2022; Whyte, 2022). The now-famous statement by US Olympic gymnast Simone Biles, 'I blame Larry Nassar and I also blame an entire system that enabled and perpetrated [*sic*] his abuse' (BBC, 2021), underscores how leadership can foster misconduct and persistent toxic cultures within the high-performance sports ecosystem. Leadership within a team or sports organization can significantly influence group norms, and leaders' actions are also likely to be shaped by what is valued through reward systems (e.g. Bissett et al., 2020; Fransen et al., 2020; Roberts et al., 2020).

Inquiries conducted across different continents confirm the occurrence of misconduct within high-performance sports settings. For example, UK Sport (2017) reported that 24% of athletes and 31% of staff experienced or witnessed unacceptable behaviors while participating in a world-class program. In a large-scale report on the US Olympic and Paralympic movement, which included more than 50 sports, nearly a third (27.5%) of athletes indicated that they considered sexual, emotional, or physical misconduct to be a problem in their sport (US Center for SafeSport, 2021). The Australian Human Rights Commission (2021) also conducted a comprehensive independent investigation of the Australian gymnastics culture and concluded: 'Current coaching practices create a risk of abuse and harm to athletes. Additionally, hiring practices for coaching staff lack accountability, and there are inconsistent policies and systems to regulate their behavior' (p. 11).

Leadership in sports has been extensively studied. Sport psychology literature has commonly focused on on-the-field team leadership (e.g. coach leadership), while sport management literature more extensively investigates off-the-field leadership (e.g. sports directors, managers, stakeholders; Peachey et al., 2015). Several leadership theories are proposed in the literature, often inspired by organizational psychology (Arthur & Bastardoz, 2020; Chelladurai, 1990, 2007; Cotterill et al., 2022; Peachey et al., 2015). These include, for example, the situational approach (Chelladurai, 2007), the social identity approach (Fransen et al., 2020, 2022; Stevens et al., 2021), and transformational leadership theory (Arthur et al., 2017; Turnnidge & Côté, 2016). Leadership research has traditionally placed the greatest focus on the study of leadership characteristics or processes under various conditions that can facilitate successful performance, goal achievement, or the welfare of followers or teams (e.g. Arthur & Bastardoz, 2020; Peachey et al., 2015). Several leadership perspectives also include elements that potentially could result in both negative and positive group outcomes. For example, building on the social identity approach, which emphasizes how leaders can foster a sense of shared identity and purpose within a group, Fransen et al. (2015) reported that leaders have the capacity to influence team members' confidence and performance in both positive and negative ways. Moreover, Javalagi et al. (2024) demonstrated through large-scale cross-cultural meta-analyses that personality traits and behaviors, moderated by cultural context (individualistic vs. collectivistic), are associated with effective leadership. These findings underscore that several leadership approaches likely have merit in predicting positive and/or negative outcomes.

Destructive or toxic leadership behaviors or processes within teams or organizations that negatively impact individuals' wellbeing and performance, and foster unethical behavior, are increasingly documented in high-performance settings such as business, politics, the military, and sports (Carleton et al., 2016; Cruickshank & Collins, 2016; Krasikova et al., 2013; Padilla et al., 2007; Schyns & Schilling, 2013; Serpell et al., 2021;

Tepper et al., 2017). High-performance sports are traditionally characterized by a 'win-at-all-costs' culture (Lundqvist et al., 2024; Roberts et al., 2020), implying a normative view that effective leadership can be evaluated through medals and sporting success (Cruickshank & Collins, 2015). The detrimental effects of leadership can be mitigated by sport performance gains aligned with the leader(s) having a high-status within the sports context. This dynamic has the potential to shape a culture and normative values, where destructive leadership become more prominent and are perceived as acceptable by coaches, sports directors, managers, and stakeholders (Carleton et al., 2016; Cruickshank & Collins, 2016; Nevicka et al., 2023; Peachey et al., 2015; Roberts et al., 2020; Serpell et al., 2021).

## Definitions and perspectives on destructive or toxic leadership

Terms such as destructive leadership, toxic leadership, aversive leadership, corrupt leadership, abusive supervision, derailed leadership, despotic leadership, leader narcissism, leader undermining, negative leadership, and tyrannical leadership are commonly employed in the study of the dark side of leadership (for reviews, see Mackey et al., 2021; Schyns & Schilling, 2013; Tepper, 2000). A significant challenge is therefore the inconsistent terminology used in research on this matter (Burns, 2017; Mackey et al., 2021; Schyns & Schilling, 2013; Tepper, 2000). These leadership terms share, however, a commonality: leaders are perceived to engage in harmful acts or methods towards one or more of their followers (Mackey et al., 2021). Lipman-Blumen (2005) broadly defined toxic leadership as: 'Individuals, who by dint of their destructive behaviors and dysfunctional personal qualities generate a serious and enduring poisonous effect on the individuals, families, organizations, communities, and even societies they lead' (p. 30). This definition implies that toxic leadership (a) concerns dysfunctional behavior(s) and (b) results in objectively detrimental consequences for those affected. However, there is currently little agreement in the literature regarding whether empirical research on toxic leadership merely captures subjective perceptions (i.e. experiences) or also entails actual harmful behaviors and/or intentions (Fischer et al., 2021; Fischer & Sitkin, 2023; Krasikova et al., 2013; Martinko et al., 2013; Thoroughgood et al., 2012).

A trait perspective has been used to explain toxic leadership, with Paulhus and Williams (2002) introducing the label 'dark triad'. This triad includes (a) Machiavellianism, characterized by manipulation, exploitation, and a lack of morality; (b) narcissism, marked by grandiosity, entitlement, and self-promotion; and (c) psychopathy, defined by impulsivity and thrill-seeking. There is, however, an ongoing debate about the number of traits, with some researchers proposing a dark dyad, triad, tetrad, or even a tent (Paulhus, 2014; Rogoza & Cieciuch, 2020). Others suggest that toxic leadership is a systemic issue, described by the 'toxic triangle', which includes leader attributes, susceptible followers, and conducive environments (Padilla et al., 2007). This triangle is characterized by coercion, manipulation, and dominance, aimed at influencing followers to meet the leader's selfish needs. Followers may align with dark leaders out of fear (conformers) or perceived personal benefit (colluders). Thus, toxic leadership may depend not only on the leader but also on willing followers and a supportive environment (Padilla et al., 2007; Thoroughgood & Padilla, 2013).

## Rationale and study purpose

Research on destructive or toxic leadership remains diverse in scope and methodology, lacking theoretical integration. Recognizing the various terms, definitions, and theoretical perspectives in the literature, we henceforth adopt the broader term 'toxic leadership' as an umbrella term for all related concepts (e.g. destructive/negative leadership styles, socially undesirable or darker personality characteristics, dysfunctional or harmful behaviors, the toxic triangle) within high-performance sports contexts.

To our knowledge, there is currently no systematic review on toxic leadership in high-performance sports that provides an overview of what is known, what is not known, and how the field can progress. Scoping reviews are suitable for exploratory research questions related to existing research on broader topics (Munn et al., 2018). However, the methodological demands are less rigorous than those for systematic reviews and meta-analyses (Colquhoun et al., 2014; Daudt et al., 2013). Scoping reviews have limitations regarding the depth and definitiveness of findings but allow for excellent breadth. They can, therefore, outline priorities for future research and provide insights that can help athletes, coaches, sport staff, stakeholders, and other involved parties in identifying and addressing toxic leadership in their own sports environments.

The purpose of this scoping review is to identify the current state of knowledge on toxic leadership in high-performance sports settings and its consequences (e.g. mental health, performance) at individual, interpersonal, and organizational levels. We followed the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses extension for Scoping Reviews (PRISMA-ScR; Tricco et al., 2018). In addition, the PICO framework (Richardson et al., 1995) was used for formulating a research question. While the PICO framework has been criticized for lacking a time element (Riva et al., 2012) and not including statistical analyses (Saaiq & Ashraf, 2017), it was deemed appropriate in the current context. The final research questions were as follows:

### *P-Problem*

What is known about the antecedents and occurrence of toxic leadership (e.g. dark triad, dark personality, socially undesirable behaviors) in high-performance sports environments?

### *I-Intervention*

How has toxic leadership been investigated in high-performance sports research?

### *C-Context*

In which high-performance sports contexts has toxic leadership been investigated?

### *O-Outcome*

What is known about the consequences of toxic leadership at an individual level (e.g. athletes, coaches), for example related to mental health, athletic performance, harassment,

and abuse? Additionally, what is known about the consequences of toxic leadership at an organizational level?

## Methods

### *Eligibility criteria*

The study protocol, including eligibility criteria, was preregistered at the Open Science Framework on 18 June 2023 (https://osf.io/tmzdh), but was subsequently updated throughout the literature search process as the authors became more familiar with the literature. The current study included only empirical, peer-reviewed articles with a full-text version available in English. Our review was initially intended to focus on adult athletes in high-performance settings. However, as many studies on toxic leadership were found to include samples of youth, adolescent, or student high-performance athletes, we decided to broaden the scope. To be included, studies needed to focus on the topic of toxic leadership in high-performance sports contexts, specifically elite sport settings from youth to senior level that had an emphasis on achieving sports excellence. Building on definitions provided by Swann et al. (2015), we included studies with samples ranging from representing semi-elite (below top-standard possible in their sport and age-group) to international senior world-class elite. We were interested in all studies that investigated either behavioral/personality characteristics among sports leaders (e.g. dark triad, negative coaching, socially undesirable behaviors) or contextual factors that serve to maintain toxic leadership. During the full-text review, studies were excluded if one or more eligibility criteria were not met or if the study focus was not clearly defined as investigating toxic leadership (in some form) in the context of high-performance sports.

### *Literature search*

We conducted a literature search using four research databases: Scopus, Psycinfo, PubMed, and Web of Science, along with a complementary search in Google Scholar. The search string was: '('dark triad' OR 'dark traits' OR dysfunctional OR toxic OR destructive OR narcissis* OR psychopath* OR Machiavellian* OR abuse OR harassment OR 'negative coaching' OR punishment) AND ('sport* coach*' OR 'sport* manag*' OR 'sport* leader*')'. Minor details of the search string format, but not the search words, were adjusted based on the requirements of the databases used. The search string was intentionally broad to identify papers discussing either dark triad traits among leaders or other forms of destructive leadership styles or behaviors within a high-performance sports setting.

The final literature search and import of references into the review software Covidence was conducted on August 20, 2023. Abstracts and titles were screened for relevance by one author (ÖK), and two authors (CL and ÖK) subsequently conducted the full-text review to screen for eligibility. After the initial voting on the inclusion or exclusion of articles, disagreements arose regarding five papers. These disagreements were resolved by reviewing the articles together and, while carefully considering the inclusion and exclusion criteria, reaching consensus through discussion. Finally, the reference lists of the reviewed papers were screened for additional papers to review.

### Data extraction

Basic data from the included articles (e.g. title, year of publication, geographic data) were extracted. Additionally, using a predetermined data extraction template, two authors (CL and ÖK) individually coded the primary aims and findings of the studies. Specifically, we described the ways in which the studies discussed the occurrence, antecedents, maintaining factors, positive and negative consequences of toxic leadership for mental health, sports, and organizational performance, and solutions suggested for managing toxic leadership, in addition to a summary of the main findings of each study.

## Results

Initially, 754 records were identified through the literature search, and 14 were subsequently added from screening reference lists resulting in a total of 768 records. After removing 111 duplicates, the titles and abstracts of 657 records were screened for relevance, of which 574 were subsequently excluded. English-language full-text versions of the remaining 85 studies were sought, and 83 were retrieved. These were assessed for eligibility, resulting in a final sample of 26 studies. Reasons for exclusions at this stage, along with additional information about the inclusion process, are presented in the PRISMA flow diagram (Figure 1). We structure our scoping review results by focusing on: (a) study characteristics, (b) definitions of toxic leadership, (c) occurrence of toxic leadership, (d) antecedents, (e) maintaining factors, (f) consequences, and (g) solutions.

### Study characteristics

Study characteristics are presented in Table 1. The majority of studies ($n = 14$) were conducted in North America. Nine ($n = 9$) studies were conducted in Europe, two ($n = 2$) in Oceania, and one ($n = 1$) in Asia. We did not limit the publication date in this scoping review, but all identified studies were published between 2004 and 2023. The majority of the studies (i.e. 16 of 26 studies) were published in 2017 or later. Leaders in adult high-performance sports were investigated in 19 studies, six ($n = 6$) studies included a mixed sample of leaders from youth and adult high-performance sports, while one ($n = 1$) study included only youth high-performance leaders. Seventeen ($n = 17$) of the studies focused on leaders in samples with senior-level elite international or Olympic athletes, while seven ($n = 7$) studies investigated leaders in high-performance sports settings involving samples with youth or student athletes.

Regarding methodology, a majority of included studies ($n = 14$) employed an interview methodology, using qualitative methods to analyze data. Six ($n = 6$) studies employed a quantitative approach, using self-report questionnaires. Of these studies, Willson and colleagues (Willson et al., 2022a; Willson et al., 2022b) constructed a custom survey to assess, amongst other things, the experience, and perceived outcomes of maltreatment in sports settings. Lopez et al. (2020) and Kim et al. (2020) used a questionnaire previously constructed by Tepper (2000) to assess abusive leadership. While Lopez et al. (2020) used all 15 items from Tepper and colleagues' scale and reported excellent internal consistency (Cronbach's $\alpha = .94$), Kim et al. (2020) used the five items of the active-aggressive abusive

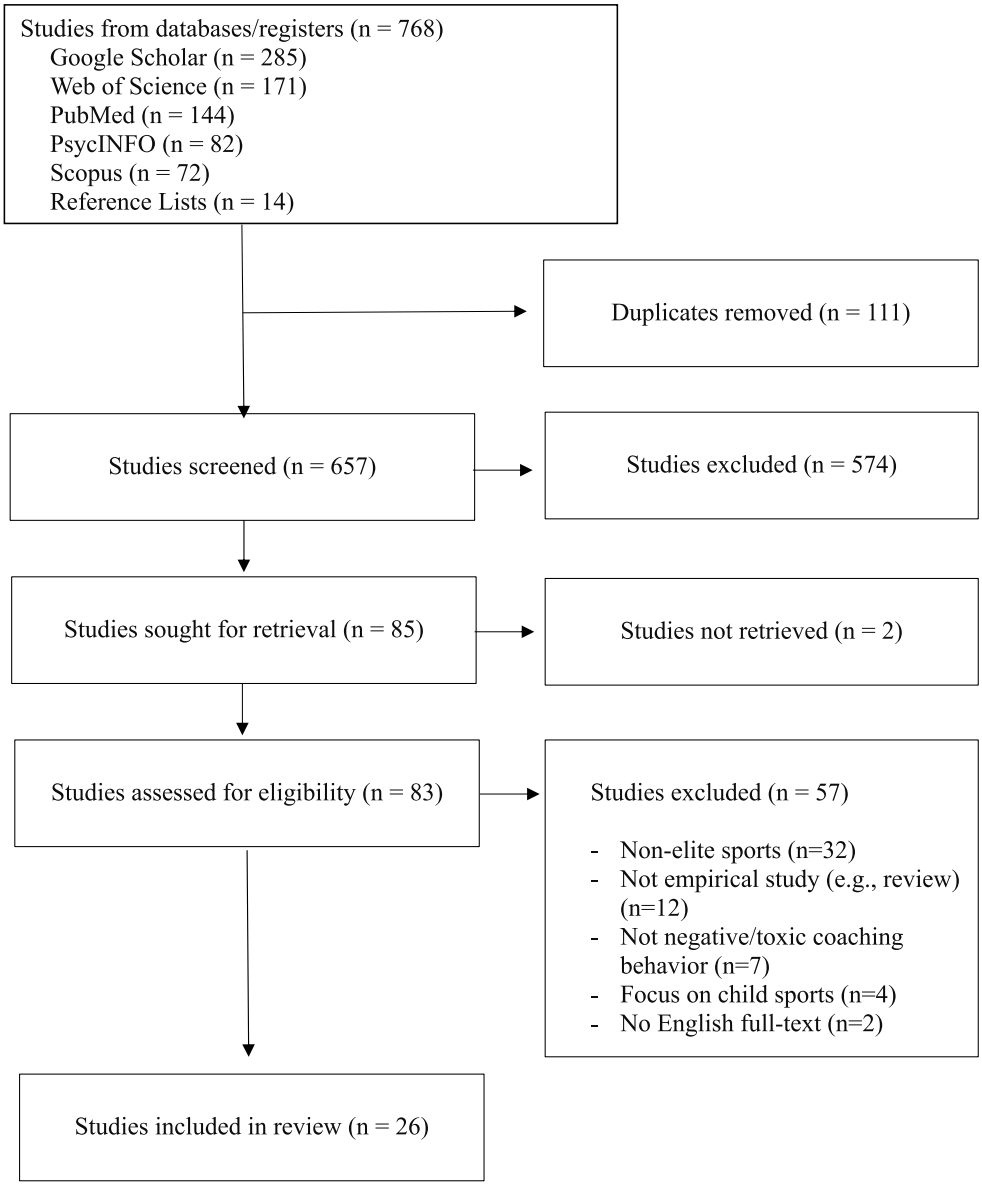


**Figure 1.** Flow diagram of abstract screening and full-text assessment for eligibility.

supervision subscale (see Mitchell & Ambrose, 2007), with a similar internal consistency (Cronbach's α = .94). Ntoumanis et al. (2017) used the Controlling Coach Behaviors Scale (Bartholomew et al., 2010) to assess controlling behavior in the coach-athlete relationship and reported a good internal reliability (α = .85). Finally, Serpell et al. (2021) used the Hogan Personality Suite (Hogan, 2009; Hogan & Hogan, 2007) to determine the darker- and lighter-side traits of leaders in high-performance sports. While Serpell et al. (2021) did not report reliability coefficients for their sample, the scales have previously shown acceptable reliability (Hogan, 2009; Hogan & Hogan, 2007).

**Table 1.** Summary of reviewed articles.

| Authors (Year) | Title | Country | Methodology | Highest competitive level | Participants | Leader in focus | Aims | Key findings |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Chroni and Kavoura (2022) | From silence to speaking up about sexual violence in Greece: Olympic journeys in a culture that neglects safety | Greece | Textual analysis | Olympic | 36 media articles | Mixed sample of leaders | Understanding underlying socio-cultural factors that facilitate acceptance, tolerance, silencing, and concealing of sexual abuse toward women occurring inside sport in Greece. | Two themes 'Keeping the house intact' and 'Failed negotiation with power' were identified as hinders for female athletes to speak up and being heard about sexual abuse. Collectivistic and patriarchal structures can maintain an abusive and sexually violent environment. |
| Cruickshank and Collins (2015) | Illuminating and applying 'the dark side': Insights from elite team leaders | United Kingdom | Interview study | Olympic | $n = 15$ | Head coaches; Sport directors | Understand the use of dark side behaviors by leaders in elite sports teams. | Dark side behaviors can be useful and viewed as necessary for successful leadership in high-performance sports. |
| Fasting and Brackenridge (2009) | Coaches, sexual harassment and education | Norway | Interview study | Olympic | $n = 19$ | Coaches | Understand how sexually harassing coaches are characterized by their victims. | Three types of coaches were identified to sexually harass female athletes: The flirting-charming, the seductive and the authoritarian coach. |
| Gervis and Dunn (2004) | The emotional abuse of elite child athletes by their coaches | United Kingdom | Interview study | Youth/adolescent elite sports | $n = 12$ | Coaches | Conduct a preliminary investigation of emotional abuse by coaches in the context of elite child sports. | All elite child athletes reported experiences of abusive behaviors from their coaches with short and long-term emotional and psychological consequences. |
| Jacobs et al. (2017) | 'You don't realize what you see!': The institutional context of emotional abuse in elite youth sport | Netherlands | Interview study | Not clearly disclosed | $n = 10$ | Coaches; Managers/ directors at lower and higher organizational levels. | Understanding the views of coaches and directors of sports clubs in relation to abusive coaching practices. | Discourses around pleasure, performance, and positive development were identified with both coaches and directors. In addition, a discourse of coach expertise was often used to legitimize various types of coaching behaviors. |
| Kavanagh et al. (2017) | Elite athletes' experience of coping with emotional abuse in the coach – athlete relationship | United Kingdom | Interview study | Senior international elite | $n = 12$ | Coaches | Explore athlete coping response to emotionally abusive coaching | Athletes use several coping strategies in response to emotional abuse in the coach-athlete relationship and continue use coping strategies to cope with memories and sequalae of emotional abuse. |
| Kerr and Stirling (2012) | Parents' reflections on their child's experiences | Canada | Interview study | Olympic | $n = 16$ | Coaches; Head coaches | Explore parents' reflections on their child experiences of | Parents are socialized into the culture of elite sports and become silent bystanders |

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| | of emotionally abusive coaching practices | | | | | | emotional abusive coaching practices. | observing but not intervening when their child is being emotionally abused in the sports setting. |
| Kerr et al. (2020) | 'It was the worst time in my life': The effects of emotionally abusive coaching on female Canadian national team athletes | Canada | Interview study | Olympic | $n = 8$ | Coaches | Investigate the longer-term effects of emotionally abusive coaching practices. | Abusive coaching has long-term negative consequences, persisting long after an athlete has ended their career. |
| Kim et al. (2020) | Hard knock coaching: A cross-cultural study of the effects of abusive leader behaviors on athlete satisfaction and commitment through interactional justice | Hong Kong & Korea | Survey/questionnaires | Elite student athletes | $n = 521$ | Coaches | Examine the extent to which collegiate coach behaviors influence athletes' satisfaction and commitment. | Abusive and supportive leadership impacted athlete commitment and satisfaction; these relationships were mediated through a sense of interactional justice. |
| Krieger and Pieper (2023) | Athlete perceptions of governance-related issues to sexual abuse in sport | United States | Textual analysis | Olympic/Paralympic | N/A | Managers/directors at higher organizational level; Other stakeholders (e.g. sports ministry) | What athletes who have reported sexual abuse believe to be the key issues in organizational governance that facilitate sexual abuse in US Olympic sport. | Several issues at various levels of governance perpetuate and cover up sexual abuse in Olympic sports. Current governance structure protects powerful persons at the expense of vulnerable athletes. |
| Lopez et al. (2020) | The effect of abusive leadership by coaches on Division I student-athletes' performance: The moderating role of core self-evaluations | United States | Survey/ questionnaires | Elite student athletes | $n = 216$ | Coaches | Investigate the negative effects of abusive leadership on athlete performance. | High core self-evaluation provides a buffering effect as a moderating variable on the negative impact of abusive leadership on student-athlete performance. |
| Lucas and Fyke (2014) | Euphemisms and ethics: A language-centered analysis of Penn State's sexual abuse scandal | United States | Textual analysis | Elite student athletes | N/A | Managers/directors at a high organizational level; Other stakeholders (e.g. sports ministry) | Investigate the use of euphemism by Penn State personnel, and the ways in which euphemism ultimately was embedded in its context and functioned to shape reality and influence decision-making. | The way that Penn State personnel spoke about actions of the perpetrator, and the euphemisms used, reduced the perceived seriousness and impact of those actions and the responsibility of everyone involved. |
| McHenry et al. (2021) | Elite figure skaters' experiences of harm in the coach-athlete relationship: A person-centered theory perspective | United States | Interview study | Senior international elite | $n = 7$ | Coaches | Understanding the coach-athlete relationship from the perspective of Rogers' person-centered theory. | Conditional negative regard was experienced in tandem with conditional positive regard. |

(*Continued*)

**Table 1.** Continued.

| Authors (Year) | Title | Country | Methodology | Highest competitive level | Participants | Leader in focus | Aims | Key findings |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Nite and Nauright (2020) | Examining institutional work that perpetuates abuse in sport organizations | United States | Textual analysis | Elite student athletes | N/A | Coaches; Managers/ directors at lower and higher organizational levels; Other stakeholders (e.g. sports ministry) | To understand how prolonged sexual abuse was allowed to exist within U.S. University athletic programs. | University and athletic officials as well as stakeholders created institutional structures that resulted in the perpetuation of sexual abuse. |
| Ntoumanis et al. (2017) | Linking coach interpersonal style with athlete doping intentions and doping use: A prospective study | Greece | Survey/ questionnaires | Senior international elite | $n = 257$ | Coaches | To test a model linking contextual and personal motivational variables, moral attitudes, moral disengagement in doping, and doping intentions with doping behaviors. | Controlling coach behavior was indirectly related to doping via needs frustration, intentions to cheat and moral disengagement. |
| Powers et al. (2016) | An investigation of destructive leadership in a Division I intercollegiate athletic department: Follower perceptions and reactions | United States | Interview study | Elite student athletes | $n = 5$ | Coaches; Head coaches; Managers/directors at lower and higher organizational levels | The role of the toxic triangle in shaping a destructive environment, and how such factors interact to produce harmful outcomes. | Toxic triangles were identified, showing how destructive leaders along with colluders, together with a lack of oversight, contributed to a destructive working environment. Destructive leadership resulted in high levels of stress among subordinates, which in turn resulted in performance decrements and compromised physical and mental health. |
| Serpell et al. (2021) | Dark traits as a potential feature of leadership in the high-performance sports coach | Australia | Survey/ questionnaires | Olympic/Paralympic | $n = 73$ | Coaches | To describe personality and leadership traits of coaches in high-performance sports. | Coaches had similar levels of light traits as leaders in other fields but had slightly higher levels of dark traits. |
| Shiakou et al. (2023) | The management of harassment and abuse in sports: A European investigation of the experts' opinions | Several countries included | Focus group discussions | N/A | $n = 53$ | Mixed sample of leaders | To collect data from sports administrators across five European countries regarding effective strategies for managing harassment and abuse. | A lack of awareness was identified regarding what constitute harassment and abuse among sports leaders, potentially serving to normalize abusive coaching behaviors. Although policies have been developed, implementation is lagging. |
| Smits et al. (2017) | 'Everything revolves around gymnastics': Athletes and parents make sense of elite youth sport | Netherlands | Interview study | Senior international elite | $n = 26$ | Coaches | Investigate the culture of elite women's' gymnastics in the Netherlands. | The contextual frame in Dutch elite gymnastics prompts athletes and parents to make sense of the abuse and harassment they experience in a |

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| | | | | | | | | way that normalize and legitimizes abusive leadership. |
| Stirling and Kerr (2008) | Defining and categorizing emotional abuse in sport | Canada | Interview study | Senior international elite | $n = 14$ | Coaches | Investigate elite athletes' experiences of emotional abuse in sporting environments. | Emotionally abusive coach behaviors occurred in three ways: through physical and verbal behaviors as well as the denial of attention and support. A definition of emotional abuse in sports is proposed. |
| Stirling and Kerr (2014) | Initiating and sustaining emotional abuse in the coach – athlete relationship: An ecological transactional model of vulnerability | Canada | Interview study | Senior international elite | $n = 18$ | Coaches | Explore the process by which emotional abuse of athletes occurs and is sustained in the coach-athlete relationship. | An ecological transactional model of vulnerability to the development of emotionally abusive coach-athlete relations is proposed. |
| Stirling and Kerr (2009) | Abused athletes' perceptions of the coach-athlete relationship | Canada | Interview study | Senior international elite | $n = 9$ | Coaches | To investigate abused athletes' perceptions of power in the coach-athlete relationship. | The study highlights power of the coach of the athlete, closeness of the coach-athlete relationship, fear of retribution if athletes report abuse, coaches' perceived expertise and the legitimate authority of the coach as factors allowing abuse to continue. |
| Stirling (2013) | Understanding the use of emotionally abusive coaching practices | Canada | Interview study | Olympic | $n = 9$ | Coaches | Explore coaches' reflection on their previous use of emotionally abusive practices in the coach-athlete relationship. | Two main origins of coaches' emotionally abusive behavior identified: Expressive (need to express their anger and frustration with the athlete) and instrumental (to achieve a specific outcome). |
| Willson et al. (2022a) | Listening to athletes' voices: National team athletes' perspectives on advancing safe sport in Canada | Canada | Survey/ questionnaires | Olympic/Paralympic | $n = 265$ | Coaches; Head coaches; Managers/directors at a lower and higher organizational level); Other stakeholders (e.g. sports ministry) | Investigate athletes' perspectives of the challenges and recommendations to advancing safe sport. | Barriers and challenges to safe sport included emphasizing performance excellence at-all-cost, normalization and complicity of harm, lack of attention to equity, diversity and inclusion, a culture of fear and silence, and a lack of trust in organizations to handle cases of harm. |
| Willson et al. (2022b) | Prevalence of maltreatment among Canadian national team athletes | Canada | Survey/ questionnaires | Olympic/Paralympic | $n = 995$ | Mixed sample of leaders | Investigate the prevalence and type of maltreatment among national team athletes along with the type and context of | Neglect and psychological harm were most frequently reported, followed by sexual and physical harm. Female athletes reported |

(*Continued*)

**Table 1.** Continued.

| Authors (Year) | Title | Country | Methodology | Highest competitive level | Participants | Leader in focus | Aims | Key findings |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | | | maltreatment, the perpetrator and identity characteristics (e.g. race, gender) that can increase the likelihood of maltreatment. | significantly more experiences of all types of harm. Retired athletes reported significantly more neglect and physical harm. Coaches were the most commonly reported perpetrator of all harms except for sexual harm, which was most frequently perpetrated by peers. |
| Zehntner et al. (2019) | Control, consent and complicity in the coaching of elite women's cycling in Australia: A media analysis | Australia | Textual analysis | Olympic/Paralympic | Articles in magazines ($n = 6$) and websites ($n = 4$) | Coaches | To extend understanding of how athletes and coaches negotiate and normalize abuse in media | The authors discuss a link between the expression of coaching practice and maltreatment of athletes. Athletes contributed to the normalization of extreme coaching practices through the misrecognition of social power embedded in the coaching intervention. |

Nineteen ($n = 19$) studies had coaches as the main leader in focus, while six ($n = 6$) investigated upper-level management or other stakeholders, such as sports ministries or national sporting organizations. Of the 17 studies that investigated leader characteristics or leader behavior in some manner, only three ($n = 3$) did so directly, while 14 studied leadership behaviors indirectly, either through interviewing athletes or by textual analysis (e.g. media reports, legal documents). Additionally, 14 studies addressed environmental factors, such as systemic issues, cultural aspects, or organizational factors contributing to toxic leadership. Finally, nine ($n = 9$) studies had an explicit aim of investigating the antecedents to toxic leadership or reasons why toxic leadership could persist or be maintained within sports organizations, while ten ($n = 10$) studies focused on consequences for athletes, in terms of, for example, performance decrements, dropout from high-performance sport, or mental health issues. Three studies ($n = 3$) focused on consequences for sports organizations related to media scandals, a destructive work environment, and effects on mental health among subordinates.

### *Definition of toxic leadership*

While the term 'toxic leadership' was not defined in any of the included papers, similar terms, such as *harmful*, *negative*, *destructive*, or *abusive* leadership were commonly used. However, only four ($n = 4$) of the 26 papers were identified as having a clear definition of the leadership they considered to be problematic (e.g. destructive, toxic). Cruickshank and Collins (2015) investigated the use of 'dark side behaviors' which was defined as the manifestation of the traits constituting the dark triad: Psychopathy, Machiavellianism, and Narcissism. Lopez et al. (2020) defined abusive leadership as instances 'when formal leaders engage in aggressive or punitive behaviors toward subordinates' (p. 131), and cited behaviors such as yelling, ridiculing, and threatening to demote a follower. Powers et al. (2016) defined destructive leadership as ' … the product of dysfunctional leaders interacting with susceptible followers within environments that are conducive to negative outcomes' (p. 298). Finally, Kim et al. (2020) used Tepper's (2000) definition of abusive leadership in terms of 'followers' perceptions of the extent to which leaders engage in sustained displays of hostile verbal and nonverbal behaviors, excluding physical violence' (p. 599). To summarize, although there is a lack of consensus on definitions in the research literature, studies tend to use socially undesirable behaviors or characteristics as indicators of toxic leadership.

### *Occurrence of toxic leadership*

While none of the included studies primarily focused on investigating the prevalence of toxic leadership in elite sports, four ($n = 4$) studies reported its occurrence in one form or another. Willson et al. (2022b) found that 75% of the 995 Canadian national team athletes who responded to their survey reported experiencing some form of maltreatment (physical, psychological, sexual, or neglect) during their time on the national team. Maltreatment was perpetrated by non-leaders, such as parents, peers, or strangers, but coaches were the most common perpetrators of neglect, psychological harm, and physical harm. Additionally, maltreatment was also perpetrated, although to a lesser degree, by high-performance directors, sport administrators, and trainers.

Two interview studies asked athletes about previous experiences of toxic leadership in the coach-athlete relationship. Stirling and Kerr (2014) reported that 15 of the 18 athletes interviewed had experienced abuse in the coach-athlete relationship during their careers. Additionally, all 15 athletes reported that the abuse occurred both during their time as youth and as adult athletes. Similarly, seven of the 11 elite figure skaters interviewed in McHenry et al. (2021) reported experiencing harmful opposites of unconditional positive regard (i.e. conditional positive regard, unconditional negative regard, or conditional negative regard).

Finally, three studies reported on coaches' own perceived use of toxic leadership practices. Coaches in Stirling (2013) were presented with a definition of emotional abuse, and five out of nine coaches interviewed reported previous use of emotionally abusive coaching practices. Cruickshank and Collins (2015) interviewed leaders at top-level sporting organizations and found that all 15 of the included leaders reported using leadership behaviors associated with dark-side traits. Relatedly, Serpell et al. (2021) found that leaders in elite sports had higher levels of three (out of eleven) dark-side traits than leaders in other settings. Overall, studies suggest that socially undesirable behaviors are prevalent in high-performance sports settings.

### *Identified antecedents of toxic leadership*

Several studies identified leaders' personality traits as an antecedent of toxic leadership. Serpell et al. (2021) and Cruickshank and Collins (2015) suggested that the increased prevalence of dark-side traits among leaders in elite sports, and the utility of darker behaviors in facilitating elite performance may increase the occurrence of toxic leadership. Fasting and Brackenridge (2009) also identified personality features, in the form of authoritarianism, as contributing to toxic leadership. In relation to cultural and organizational norms, Zehntner et al. (2019) suggested that normalization of extreme athlete behaviors (i.e. extreme practice regimes) may similarly serve to normalize extreme and abusive coaching behavior. In line with these results, Stirling and Kerr (2014) presented a model of emotionally abusive coaching practices where unrealistic performance expectations and an athlete development philosophy that promotes corporal punishment are seen as antecedents of emotional abuse in the coach-athlete relationship, along with poor anger management skills and unrelated life stressors. In Stirling (2013), coaches cited their own history of maltreatment by coaches and parents, witnessing other coaches' harmful coaching behavior, athletes' acceptance of abusive coaching, and a lack of knowledge of alternative strategies, as potential causes for their own emotionally abusive coaching practices. Finally, Shiakou et al. (2023) suggest that there may be an additional lack of knowledge among leaders in elite sports regarding what constitutes abusive coaching and toxic leadership.

### *Maintaining factors of toxic leadership*

Several studies identified the power differential in the coach-athlete relationship, and other relationships between athletes and leaders in sports, as an important aspect maintaining toxic leadership practices (Krieger & Pieper, 2023; McHenry et al., 2021; Stirling & Kerr, 2008, 2009). As an example, athletes in Stirling and Kerr (2009) perceived coaches and other

leaders to have significant influence over their future careers. Speaking up against abusive leadership practices was perceived to impact athletic careers in a negative way and several studies found that athletes experienced a significant fear of potential repercussions (Chroni & Kavoura, 2022; Kerr & Stirling, 2012; Krieger & Pieper, 2023; Stirling & Kerr, 2009; Willson et al., 2022a). The power differential and associated fear of reprisal was also found to significantly contribute to a second, highly prevalent, theme, namely that of a code of silence surrounding toxic leadership practices in elite sports (Nite & Nauright, 2020; Shiakou et al., 2023; Willson et al., 2022a). When victims of abusive leaders attempted to speak up, studies showed they were quickly silenced by their surroundings to protect the leader, especially when that leader was perceived to be effective and successful (Krieger & Pieper, 2023; Nite & Nauright, 2020; Willson et al., 2022a).

Multiple studies investigated cultural and organizational norms, as well as institutional practices, that function to silence those attempting to speak up against toxic leadership and abusive leadership practices. Among the most prominently cited norms are those of 'toughness' (Zehntner et al., 2019), sport being a masculine domain (Fasting & Brackenridge, 2009) and a performance-based value system (Jacobs et al., 2017; Smits et al., 2017; Stirling & Kerr, 2014; Zehntner et al., 2019). The leadership of successful leaders, whether toxic or not, was tolerated, and even encouraged, as long as the leadership was perceived to facilitate successful performance. For instance, Nite and Nauright (2020) as well as Krieger and Pieper (2023) showed how *valorization*, highlighting the positive contributions and accomplishments of an alleged perpetrator of abuse, served to minimize the negative implications of the actions. Valorizing the actions of alleged perpetrators simultaneously served to delegitimize the claims of alleged victims. An additional example was provided by Lucas and Fyke (2014), who showed how euphemistic language (i.e. using mild or vague language to refer to a socially inappropriate topic in a polite manner) used by university personnel served to obscure and minimize unacceptable actions and their negative consequences. Thus, a perpetrator was protected because of the person's perceived value and contributions to the university's successful sports program. Several studies also highlighted commercialization of elite sports and institutional practices such as internal and obscure disciplinary procedures, non-public and slow investigations, missing mechanisms for reporting abuse, outdated legal codes and codes of conduct, and conventions of holding practice behind closed doors (Chroni & Kavoura, 2022; Gervis & Dunn, 2004; Krieger & Pieper, 2023; Nite & Nauright, 2020). Together, the abovementioned factors contributed to athletes and other followers passively witnessing and accepting toxic leadership (Powers et al., 2016). Indeed, Kavanagh et al. (2017) found that athletes developed several coping strategies specifically to endure abusive leadership practices.

### *Consequences of toxic leadership*

The most described negative consequence of toxic leadership in the reviewed studies was the negative impact on athlete mental health (Gervis & Dunn, 2004; Jacobs et al., 2017; Kavanagh et al., 2017; Kerr et al., 2020; Stirling & Kerr, 2008; Willson et al., 2022b). For example, Kerr et al. (2020) found that former national team athletes who had experienced emotionally abusive coaching practices reported a long-term impact on their mental health, and symptoms similar to those reported in patients with post-traumatic stress

disorder. Additionally, respondents in Kerr et al. (2020) reported that the emotionally abusive coaching had a negative impact on athletes' view of the sport and had sometimes impacted their decisions to retire early. These results are mirrored in several other studies, suggesting that toxic leadership increases the risk of dropout and early retirement from elite sports (Chroni & Kavoura, 2022; Kavanagh et al., 2017; Kim et al., 2020; Stirling & Kerr, 2014). Additionally, toxic leadership was linked to physical injuries (Smits et al., 2017), low self-confidence and self-esteem, as well as a lack of motivation (Gervis & Dunn, 2004; McHenry et al., 2021), increased risk of cheating and doping intentions among athletes (Ntoumanis et al., 2017), and organizational chaos, confusion, cover-ups, negative mental health and turnover among sports personnel (Lucas & Fyke, 2014; Powers et al., 2016).

Some studies discussed that leadership behaviors generally considered toxic can sometimes enhance athlete performance and resilience. However, none of these studies demonstrated an empirical relationship between toxic leadership practices and improved performance. Six studies, however, discussed the possibility that certain dark-side leadership behaviors might be related to performance gains (Cruickshank & Collins, 2015; Jacobs et al., 2017; Kerr et al., 2020; Serpell et al., 2021; Smits et al., 2017; Stirling & Kerr, 2009). Specifically, athletes and coaches expressed the view that toxic leadership behaviors may serve to increase mental toughness or 'build character' among athletes, which in turn is assumed to increase performance potential (Jacobs et al., 2017; Kerr et al., 2020). Coaches in Cruickshank and Collins (2015) also suggested that certain dark side coach behaviors, such as being overly critical of others or ostracizing individuals for the purpose of social dominance, may be beneficial for a coach's role survival (e.g. not getting fired, advancing their careers). Finally, Cruickshank and Collins (2015) and Serpell et al., 2021 speculated that darker traits and behaviors may be useful in manipulating athletes and other followers to achieve performance goals. In Table 2, identified antecedents, maintaining factors and consequences of toxic leadership are summarized.

### *Solutions to reduce toxic leadership*

Regarding potential solutions minimizing the negative impact of toxic leadership in high-performance sports, some authors suggest that coaches need to receive additional training and education (Kavanagh et al., 2017; Kim et al., 2020; McHenry et al., 2021; Powers et al., 2016; Stirling, 2013; Stirling & Kerr, 2014). For example, Stirling and Kerr (2014) suggest that '… emotionally abusive coaching practices might be best prevented through an enhanced focus on the education of coaches on ethical coaching conduct and alternative, nonabusive philosophies and strategies for athlete development' (p. 132). Stirling and Kerr additionally suggested that reducing the power gap between athletes and coaches may similarly serve to reduce abusive coaching. One avenue would be to promote a more holistic view of the athlete, deemphasizing (while not disregarding) the importance of performance and increasing attention to general wellbeing (Stirling & Kerr, 2009; Willson et al., 2022a). Increasing athlete autonomy and including athletes in decision-making processes would similarly serve to divide power between athletes and leaders (Kavanagh et al., 2017).

Several authors suggested that comprehensive changes need to be made on an institutional level (Jacobs et al., 2017; Krieger & Pieper, 2023; Shiakou et al., 2023; Cruickshank

**Table 2.** A summary of antecedents, maintaining factors, and consequences of toxic leadership as identified in studies on high-performance sports.

| Antecedents of toxic leadership | Maintaining factors of toxic leadership | Consequences of toxic leadership |
|---|---|---|
| • Dark personality traits or behaviors<br>• Normalization of destructive or extreme coaching behaviors as part of the sport culture<br>• Unrealistic performance expectations<br>• Lack of knowledge what constitute toxic leadership and lack of alternative strategies | • Power structures and dynamics in sports/organizations<br>• High-status coaches having a significant influence over athletes' future sports careers<br>• Fears of repercussions, a code of silence/silencing of those who speak up<br>• Performance-based value system with toxic leadership tolerated or encouraged in the pursuit of successful performance<br>• Euphemistic language to obscure and minimize unacceptable actions and their negative consequences<br>• Institutional practices: internal and obscure disciplinary procedures, non-public and slow investigations, missing mechanisms for reporting misconduct, outdated legal codes/ codes of conduct, and conventions of holding practices behind closed doors | • Short-term and long-term negative impacts on athlete mental health<br>• Reduced athlete motivation and dropout/early retirement from elite sports<br>• Physical injuries<br>• Increased risk of cheating and doping intentions<br>• Assumptions about being 'character-building', without empirical data<br>• Survival and career gains for the leader(s) in the prevailing sport system<br>• Organizational disarray, negative mental health and turnover among sports personnel |

and Collins, 2015; Stirling & Kerr, 2008). Shiakou et al. (2023) and Liao et al. (2018), for example, highlighted the importance of establishing external oversight bodies and providing independent whistleblower functions, allowing athletes to report abuse without fear of repercussion. Codes of conduct, ethics statements, and safeguarding policies encouraging positive leadership and protecting athletes from abusive and toxic leadership have also been suggested (Stirling, 2013; Stirling & Kerr, 2008; Willson et al., 2022a). However, as noted by Shiakou et al. (2023), recent years have seen an increasing number of measures taken to protect athletes and promote safe sports, yet it is debatable whether significant progress has been made. Shiakou et al. argued that understanding why policies can fail is crucial to designing new and effective policies and interventions to decrease the risk of harassment and abuse in sports. Cruickshank and Collins (2015) proposed that high performance leadership models in sports should focus on expertise (i.e. appropriate use of effective leadership behavior), rather than competence (i.e. abilities and personality traits). Moreover, they suggested that darker and brighter behaviors may both be effective, and that leaders need to be aware of their potential uses and consequences to lead effectively.

## Discussion

By adopting broad search terms, our scoping review identified 26 articles under the umbrella term of toxic leadership in high-performance sports contexts. Most studies included adult samples, predominantly in North American and European contexts. This geographical limitation hinders the exploration of how cultural variations across different countries and sports systems worldwide may influence the interpretation of toxic leadership in high-performance sports environments. Moreover, the primary focus

of research in this domain has been on various forms of athlete maltreatment. Only a limited number of studies explicitly investigated the nuances of toxic or darker forms of leadership and their direct consequences on athletes, subordinate leaders, or sports organizations. This limited research is noteworthy, given that toxic leadership within organizations (e.g. clubs, federations, governing bodies) could have profound implications, not only for individual athletes or coaches but also potentially for undermining the ethical and moral foundations of the sporting community. We summarize the main implications of our findings and suggest directions for future research.

First, our scoping review highlighted the inconsistent use of definitions, theoretical frameworks, and methodological approaches in studies related to toxic leadership in high-performance sports. We urge future researchers to use explicit definitions and adopt methodologies that adequately capture the darker or more toxic leader behaviors, leader characteristics, leadership processes and contexts that aid to maintain toxic leadership, assessing also the severity and impact on individuals and organizations in sports (e.g. through validated scales or structured interview protocols). Definitions, theories, and existing knowledge from organizational contexts could potentially be integrated within the high-performance sports milieu, while remaining cognizant of potential precursors and mechanisms unique to the sports domain (e.g. contracts contingent upon successful sports results, roles within organizations performed on an entirely or partially voluntary basis). Such an approach will allow the high-performance sports literature to benefit from knowledge and perspectives from related disciplines while acknowledging the unique characteristics that may exist within high-performance sports settings.

Second, the results of this scoping review suggest a variety of antecedents and maintaining factors to toxic leadership, such as individual characteristics of leaders, a win-at-all-costs philosophy, status and power structures, poor examples from leaders' previous role models, lack of reporting measures or consequences within organizations, and unrelated stressors. Similarly, previous reviews on related subjects (e.g. non-accidental violence in sports; Mountjoy et al., 2016; Roberts et al., 2020), as well as findings from the broader leadership literature (Erickson et al., 2015; Mackey et al., 2021; Tepper et al., 2017), propose a combination of individual and systemic factors that can sustain toxic leadership. Factors known to facilitate toxic leadership in non-sporting but performance-oriented organizations may have analogous influences in high-performance sports. An interesting avenue for future research would be to adopt Trait Activation Theory (Tett et al., 2021) to better understand the emergence of toxic leadership behaviors in high-performance sports contexts. The Trait Activation Theory posits that individual characteristics do not operate independently from the broader context but are instead activated or inhibited depending on the situation in which they operate. Therefore, we recommend that future researchers simultaneously investigate individual traits of leaders and situational characteristics of the high-performance sports context to better understand how they together predict the emergence of toxic leadership (see de Vries, 2018).

Third, our scoping review indicated that the empirical literature to date has provided some initial support for the negative consequences of toxic leadership on athletes' mental health, injuries, and motivation to remain in high-performance sports (e.g. Gervis & Dunn, 2004; Jacobs et al., 2017; Kavanagh et al., 2017; Kerr et al., 2020; Stirling & Kerr, 2008, 2014; Willson et al., 2022b). Sparse research was found that investigated the consequences on

sports organizations. While researchers in some studies (e.g. Cruickshank & Collins, 2015; Jacobs et al., 2017; Serpell et al., 2021) discussed that leadership behaviors perceived as toxic might potentially provide performance gains by fostering mental toughness, character, or resilience, our review did not uncover any empirical evidence supporting these assumptions. Researchers have previously expressed concerns that harmful and abusive leadership cultures and exploitative practices within sports organizations persist normalized and unchallenged, despite indications that they are widespread and pose risks to the wellbeing and dropout of those involved (e.g. Kavanagh et al., 2017; Roberts et al., 2020). Moving forward, researchers should carefully weigh any potential benefits of toxic leadership behaviors against possible short-term and long-term detriments, including, but not limited to, mental health implications, risk of injuries, and early retirement from high-performance sports.

Fourth, scholars in some studies have suggested potential benefits for leaders themselves when engaging in toxic leadership (e.g. safeguarding their position, managing the complex sociopolitical high-performance sports landscape; Cruickshank & Collins, 2015). Our scoping review found limited empirical research showing beneficial effects on high-performance leaders' wellbeing, performance, and career development. Previous research suggests that enacting abusive supervision, for example, can be linked with recovery benefits when facing high job demands (Qin et al., 2018), but can also result in increased guilt (Liao et al., 2018), diminished self-worth, and reduced performance (Priesemuth & Bigelow, 2020). Although these studies were not conducted within high-performance sports contexts, they do suggest that leaders are affected by their own actions. We therefore call for future research to investigate how leaders in high-performance sports contexts might be impacted by their own display of toxic leadership. Such research could enhance our understanding of the processes underlying cycles of toxic leadership and may provide avenues for minimizing its prevalence.

Fifth, of the 26 papers identified in our scoping review that specifically searched for elements considered to fall under the toxic leadership umbrella, only six utilized a quantitative design. Leadership scales, for example, the Leadership Scale for Sports (LSS; Chelladurai & Saleh, 1980), the Coaching Behaviour Scale for Sport (CBS-S; Côté et al., 1999) and Differentiated Transformational Leadership Inventory (DTLI; Callow et al., 2009) have been used in leadership sports research, but they generally do not explicitly measure aspects of toxic leadership. The LSS includes, for example, an autocratic leadership subscale, which is traditionally considered a less successful or effective leadership but does not necessarily represent leadership perceived by followers as toxic or destructive. Serpell et al. (2021), identified in the present scoping review, attempted to measure traits related to socially undesirable behavior, so-called 'dark traits,' by use of The Hogan Personality Suite (Hogan, 2009; Hogan & Hogan, 2007), yet there is still a lack of evidence clearly linking these dark traits to toxic leadership behaviors.

Just over half of the articles identified in this scoping review employed a qualitative research design. Both qualitative and quantitative research designs have their merits and pitfalls, but this preponderance of qualitative research is striking compared to the general leadership literature, where quantitative research designs are predominant (e.g. Atwater et al., 2016; Fischer et al., 2021; Mackey et al., 2021). We do not recommend abandoning the qualitative approach to studying toxic leadership in high-performance sports; however, we suggest a greater use of high-quality quantitative research designs to

complement our understanding of the magnitude of toxic leadership and its relationships with both antecedents and consequences. A crucial step in this regard is the use of validated scales to capture toxic leadership in high-performance sports contexts. While researchers might draw inspiration from the general leadership literature (e.g. Fischer et al., 2021; Tepper, 2000) to develop scales specifically tailored for measuring toxic leadership, we recommend that they also consider the sports literature (e.g. Chelladurai & Saleh, 1980; Teques et al., 2021), which accounts for cultural aspects and other distinctive characteristics of sports.

Finally, in line with the ongoing debate in the overarching leadership literature (Fischer et al., 2021; Fischer & Sitkin, 2023; Tepper et al., 2017), and findings in this scoping review that toxic leadership was in general poorly defined in studies, we encourage researchers to differentiate between leaders' intentions, leaders' behaviors, and targets' (or others') perceptions with regards to toxic leadership. To fully grasp what causes toxic leadership and how it affects the sporting environment, toxic leadership should also be approached in a nuanced manner. There might be instances where bad intentions and actual problematic behaviors by leaders are interpreted in an overly positive manner by the environment and thereby are less detrimental or even remain unnoticed for those involved (Yu & Duffy, 2021). Similarly, some leaders could have good intentions and/or even refrain from displaying problematic leadership behaviors yet are still perceived as toxic by one or more of their followers. Adopting a more nuanced approach in future research will enhance our understanding of the emergence, maintenance, and consequences of toxic leadership in high-performance sports, and provide better guidance on addressing such situations.

We conclude that research on toxic leadership in high-performance sports is still in its early stages. Building upon our findings and existing definitions from non-sports contexts

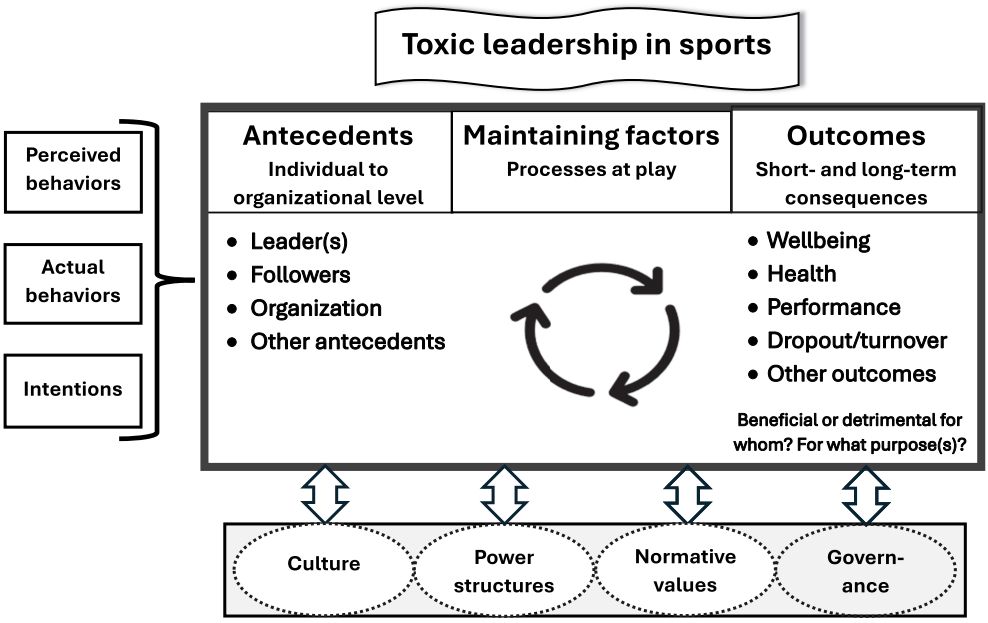


**Figure 2.** Working model of toxic leadership in sports.

(e.g. Lipman-Blumen, 2005; Mackey et al., 2021), we propose that toxic leadership in sports should be viewed as a broad umbrella term encompassing various destructive, harmful, or socially undesirable leadership characteristics, behaviors, or intentions, as well as aligned processes that enable and maintain such leadership within the sports or organizational context. This ultimately results in perceived or actual short-term or long-term detrimental outcomes for those affected (e.g. individuals, sports organizations, sports communities). In Figure 2, we present a working model designed to guide future researchers in their studies of toxic leadership. With the model we encourage researchers to clarify and explicitly define important elements under study in terms of antecedents, maintaining factors, or outcomes, as well as perspectives from which the research is conducted (e.g. the leader's traits or behaviors or related processes or factors such as culture, power structures, normative values and governance). Additionally, we recommend considering whether the focus is on leadership intentions, actual behaviors, or perceptions of intentions/behaviors, as well as the level of analysis (individual, team, organizational), including how these levels potentially interact within the sports ecological system. Furthermore, it is important to specify for whom and for what purposes the leadership could be beneficial or detrimental, and to identify potential outcomes for leaders, subordinates and third parties (e.g. wellbeing, health, performance, dropout/turnover).

In the present scoping review, we could not identify many empirically evaluated recommendations on how to effectively address toxic leadership or its adverse effects on athletes, subordinates, and organizations. However, our findings suggest that researchers, governing bodies, and sports organizations need to work together to increase knowledge and awareness of toxic leadership in high-performance sports and to develop strategies to address its occurrence and prevent negative consequences. In undertaking such an endeavour, principles of evidence-based management (Barends, 2015) could be useful, as they combine four critical sources of evidence to both understand and address the problem (e.g. toxic leadership): scientific results, professional expertise, organizational data, and stakeholder feedback. To curb the prevalence of toxic leadership within high-performance sports, we suggest that scientific knowledge should be combined with reliable data collected from the specific governing body or sport organization under investigation. Moreover, strategies should be developed collaboratively with key figures within the governing body or sport organization (e.g. athletes, coaches, managers, stakeholders) and those with extensive professional experience in addressing toxic leadership (e.g. psychologists). Adopting such a multifaceted approach helps to ensure widespread effectiveness and acceptance within the sports community and ensures that the strategies developed to mitigate or prevent toxic leadership are grounded in a comprehensive evidence base.

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